

PTI

The Patna Punter

› **From being 'down and out' when the Bihar poll was announced to leading the NDA to victory, Nitish Kumar has been the comeback king of the year**

› **Voters wanted a government that gets things done, and the CM's record—both substantive and perceived—offered that reassurance**

› **The poll win also highlighted Nitish's prescience in cultivating women as a faithful, caste-neutral electoral bloc**

That nimble integration of ideology with pragmatic politics is what has conferred on him a wide variety of descriptors: from 'Sushaasan Babu' to 'Paltu Ram', one pointing to good governance, the other to how good he is at remaining in government! Indeed, Nitish has maintained his authority by practising what some analysts call 'strategic mutability', the ability to shift political alignments. That he manages to do so while retaining his loyal cohort of depressed caste voters is what invests it with legitimacy, making him a political constant in a state not short of variables.

Nitish's brand of political steadiness has had an electoral shelf-life far longer than most pundits would have imagined

For two decades, this self-portrait has proved remarkably durable. It appeals to those who crave a semblance of orderly governance and is also useful to those who would borrow the legitimacy. Still, there is a paradox at the heart of such political longevity. It demands a public language of scruples and a private eye on the main chance. Nitish has honed both. In public, he speaks of roads, electricity, law and order; in private, he negotiates alliances with a cool arithmetic that can appear disconcerting to the uninitiated. A decade ago, he was lauded as the man who ended communal tumult and ushered in "good governance". In more recent years, the same manoeuvres have been recast by critics as opportunism. The truth can perhaps be backdated, but Nitish's cheque remains valid into the future.

That steadiness is a balm in a state where caste rhythms and local patronage networks continue to shape political choice. Nitish has, with mixed success, converted administrative competence into electoral capital. This mattered in 2025 when, amid national narratives and local anxieties, many voters told pollsters they wanted a government that would simply get things done. Nitish's record offered that reassurance.

If the 10th-time CM status is historic in scale, it is also a reminder that political durability in contemporary India demands a hybrid skillset: narrative credibility, administrative competence and alliance-making agility. Nitish has spent 20 years perfecting this craft. That he remains at the epicentre of Bihar's politics is an argument for a politics that privileges predictability and delivery over maximalist rhetoric. ■